

WCET4 - Graham Nelson-Zutter - EA FM4 Meditation - CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

(0:00 - 1:08)

The following is a meditation for the fourth fundamental motivation of existential analysis, helping us answer the question of, for what should I live my life? We offer an experience of the possibility of what it could be like to live with meaning in your life. The speaker and creator is Graham Nelson-Zutter. Please take a moment to find a seated position where your back is supported, you feel comfortable, and you have the ability to place your feet on the ground.

You may find that sitting in lotus feels comfortable for you. Just ask yourself if it's possible for this position to be more comfortable. Perhaps if seated in lotus, you may even place bolsters or pillows under your legs.

(1:08 - 2:58)

And if seated in a chair or couch, just adjusting your posture, giving yourself the opportunity to have some alignment between your spinal column and your head, noticing if you're leaning forward, backwards, or to a side, just seeing if there's a possibility to have more vertical alignment, and inviting you, if you're not able to do so, to find pillows or some form of neck support for your neck and head to ensure that there's no strain. And once you find yourself in this position, I invite you to gently rest your hands on your lap, maybe check and see your temperature, noticing if there are any adjustments that can be made. Once you're seated comfortably, to take a moment and feel support from underneath, noticing that the support in the floor and the support in the chair and couch are connected to a larger network of support.

(3:02 - 4:15)

The floor that you're on is connected to a structure of a building, which is connected to a foundation, and this foundation is resting in the earth. Just as this building rests on its foundations in the earth, you too sit here in this chair, on this floor, sharing in the support, inviting the groundedness of the earth to come up through the foundations of this building, the structure of this building, to the floor, to your feet, and to your lower legs, upper legs, glutes, and sitting bones. Asking yourself if it's possible to invite more of this grounded energy into your body.

(4:19 - 8:53)

The idea of electrical grounding or energy grounding might become helpful here, thinking of how excess energy that might be present in your body has the opportunity now to go through your feet to find some balance, and this excess of energy is able to leave and dissipate through your body gently without any effort, and as that charge leaves your body, just checking to see if you're willing to accept this grounded energy in its place, inviting this balance within the body, and shifting your attention to your breath without the need to change how you're breathing, just

noticing that you've been breathing this whole time. There's no need to control how you're breathing, and it can be helpful to notice that you are inviting this oxygen-rich air into the openness of your lungs as they expand, and as you exhale, allowing this carbon dioxide to release, to relax out of your body, both the in-breath and out-breath, not requiring any additional effort, holding the awareness that your body will continue to breathe whether you focus on the breath or not. You may recall that the oxygen you breathe is part of the oxygen that all of the beautiful plants of this earth create.

As the as the photon hits the carbon dioxide molecule, the very same carbon dioxide you exhale, the light splits the CO₂ into carbon and oxygen, the plant keeping the carbon for its growth and releasing the oxygen back into the air for you to breathe the very same oxygen that you're breathing now with every inhale. You may notice places where your skin is exposed to the air, just noticing what it's like to be in contact with the air, and you're also wearing a mask. You may notice places where your skin is covered with clothing, sticking in this difference in temperature, perhaps noticing texture or light pressure of your clothing, becoming aware again that you have this flexible boundary between you and the world.

(8:55 - 11:31)

Wherever you go, your skin and your clothing go with you. Again, nothing is required for you to do here. This natural, flexible boundary is here to protect you, whether you focus on it or not.

Your breathing will continue to nourish your body with rich oxygen from these plants, whether you focus on it or not, and the earth will continue to support you, holding you from below, whether you focus on it or not. In our previous journey together, we had the delightful experience of encountering our special tree, and I invite you at this time to meander down the paths that lead you from your home to this park or meadow, making your way back to your beautiful tree. And as you come upon the tree, noticing again its shape, its width and height, the shape and color of its canopy, noticing its branches, its bows and its trunk, and noticing whether it has leaves or needles and the color of these leaves and needles.

And as you continue to walk gently towards your tree, something new is visible to you. Your tree has started to change in a really interesting way. As you look at the branches of your tree, you notice that they seem laden, bending downwards in a way that they hadn't been before.

(11:33 - 13:52)

And as you get closer and closer to the branches, you notice that this tree has produced fruit. Now, the nature of the fruit of your tree will be specific to your tree, and I invite you to allow this fruit to emerge in just the way that it chooses. The fruit of your tree may be known to you.

It may be a type of fruit that you are aware of. It may also show up as something new and unique that you've never seen before. I invite you to allow the fruiting of this tree to be exactly as it is,

showing up with curiosity about the nature of this fruit.

For some, the fruit may be fleshy and may have a large seed within. For others, the fruit may be fleshy and have many small seeds within. For others, the fruit may be hard like a nut.

And for others, the fruit may appear more like a cone of some kind with texture. Just take a moment to really notice the color, the shape, the texture, the weight of your tree's fruit. And as you look at the ripe fruit on the branches of your tree, you notice that some of this fruit has already fallen.

(13:54 - 14:27)

And as you turn your gaze downwards towards your feet, you notice that below the branches of your tree, some of its fruit has already fallen to the earth, resting gently in grasses or moss. You find a fully intact fruit. This fruit has no bruises and is ripe and ready.

(14:29 - 19:58)

And you reach down and pick up the fruit left to you, offered to you by your tree. As you hold your fruit, noticing its weight, how hard or soft it is, bringing it up to your nose and smelling it, noticing if it has smells that are more sugary or sweet or pungent or perhaps more woody and nutty or something entirely new and different. Just taking the time to allow your senses to notice what this fruit is like.

And luckily, you've brought a bag with you. And you take a moment to gently place this fruit inside your bag, looking upward to your tree, letting the tree know that you intend to enjoy and take care of this fruit. Perhaps offering some thanks for the unexpected, beautiful gift and letting your tree know that you'll be heading home and that you look forward to the next time that you encounter each other.

And then gently churning away towards the path that leads out of the meadow and the park towards your home. As you make your way home, you feel the bag, thinking about the fruit within it. And you're suddenly aware that not only is this fruit, it's also a seed.

On your way home, as you ponder this unexpected gift, you contemplate the idea, the possibility that this seed holds the power and ability to become a whole new tree under the right conditions, with the right support, with the right care, with the right protection, with the right amount of water and attention. This seed could become a little version of your tree. And it dawns on you that at your home, you have some potting soil.

You recall that in your home, there's a really nice place in front of a window where you could plant and nurse a baby tree. As you get home, you find your soil, you find a little cup with holes or a little nursing pot, and you prepare the location for this seed to begin this process of transforming into a baby tree. If your fruit has flesh, then you gently remove this flesh from your tree.

You may notice that this flesh is either edible or not edible. Trusting your instincts around this choice and deciding whether the smell and flavor of this fruit is one that you choose to consume or don't, and you collect the seeds or pit from this fruit, making sure it's nice, clean, and ready to be planted. Somehow you know just how deep in the soil your seed should be.

For some seeds, they need to be a few inches down. For others, only a centimeter or two. And for other seeds, they prefer to rest atop the soil.

(20:00 - 21:51)

Somehow you know exactly the right way to plant your seed. And you give just the right amount of water to your seed, wetting the soil on this first day. And you feel this sense of hopefulness and contentment, this unexpected possibility of new life, this desire to care for another living being.

And noticing how the relationship with you and your tree has the possibility of becoming something new. It's possible that you may be caring for the child of this beautiful tree that you found in the park. And content with this opportunity, you go about your day, eventually going to sleep.

The following day, you wake, checking in on your seed, noticing that the soil could use some water. You go ahead and water the soil, noticing as you put this effort into supporting the possibility of this new growth, there is this building sense of excitement and anticipation. Something cool might happen.

(21:52 - 22:34)

And if you continue your efforts, you may just discover that your seed has sprouted. And you go about your day doing the things you do. And you come home, going back to sleep, waking again, watering your seed again, checking to see if it sprouted.

Not yet, but maybe soon. And you go about your day doing the things you do. And you return home and go to bed again.

(22:36 - 24:33)

And the following morning, you get up and you check on your seed again, watering the soil again, noticing not yet. It hasn't sprouted. Hoping that it will soon.

And you go about your day again and come home and eventually go back to sleep and wake again. And this cycle continues each day with you tending to the seed, making sure it's nice and moist, that there's enough water for it to wake from its slumber. And you wake again, going to check in on your seed.

And much to your delight and surprise, you discover a little green shoot sticking out of the soil. What a delight. All of your efforts have gone towards this critical moment, this beautiful moment where you can tell that the seed has awoken and a baby tree is now sprouting.

Soon after this moment, you find yourself walking around and you have this urge to go and see your big tree in the park that you've been going to. And there's this feeling of excitement and anticipation. You're going to let this tree know that its seed has produced offspring and there's a little baby tree in your house.

(24:35 - 24:58)

And off you go to your park and you go see your big tree and you let your tree know the good news. And there's this shift, subtle shift in the relationship between you and this wonderful tree. There's a sense of connection and responsibility and possibility that wasn't there before.

(24:59 - 25:21)

The connection was lovely and yet there's something new and special here. This possibility of life in the future, something growing into something bigger. And there's a sense of glow between you and this big tree, the parent tree in the park.

(25:23 - 29:11)

And having had a moment of appreciation and connection and hopefulness with this big tree, you decide to take the path, eventually returning to your home. And you go to bed and you wake up the next morning and discover that this beautiful little sprout is even taller than it was the day before. And with care and excitement and encouragement, you offer this sprouting baby tree more water.

And you go about your day with this special glow, knowing that you're involved fundamentally in supporting the growth of life itself. And this big, beautiful tree that's been so kind to you, that's offered you a place of relaxation, a place of support and protection, you're able to do something nice in reciprocity with this tree. Your care, your attention and your appreciation for the fruit and seed from this tree has resulted in this beautiful baby tree growing bit by bit in your home.

And every day you check in on this baby tree, noticing its progress. And every night you go to sleep with this feeling of having contributed to the life of another living creature, knowing that this is also the offspring, the child of that big, beautiful tree, your favorite tree in the park. And day by day, week by week, this baby tree gets bigger and bigger to the point where you notice that it's outgrown its pot.

It's time for a new pot. And with care and gentleness, you prepare the new pot with more potting soil and you help loosen the roots of the baby. And you transplant this beautiful baby tree into its

new pot.

And position the new pot, again, close to the window where this growing baby tree gets lots of light. Just the right amount of light for what it prefers, offering more water and welcoming it into its new pot. And as the days go on and the weeks go on, this baby tree grows and grows to the point where it doesn't really feel like it's a baby anymore.

And yet again, you notice that it's outgrown the pot that it's in. And you find the lovely new pot for it and even more potting soil. And you prepare the soil to transplant this baby tree, or now adolescent tree, yet again, loosening its roots, placing it in the new pot with new soil, and offering it water to help it grow.

(29:13 - 32:37)

Again, positioning it near the window with just the right amount of light for it to thrive. And as the days go on, and as the weeks go on, you discover again that this little one has grown and grown and now is ready for a new pot yet again. And you prepare this new pot with care, with fresh soil, and you transplant this adolescent tree into its new pot again, loosening its roots, allowing it to settle into its new pot with fresh water.

Again, placed by the window with just the right amount of sunlight for this adolescent plant to thrive. And the days go by, and the weeks go by, and the months go by. And before you know it, this adolescent tree is as tall as you.

It has definitely outgrown its pot yet again. And it's now time to consider whether it could go outside. And although you love having this beautiful tree in your home, this tree is getting big and strong and is ready to be out there in the world, participating in nature.

And as you consider this, although there's some sadness that this tree won't be inside your home every day to enjoy, there's this possibility of a perfect location. As you think about where this tree could live outside, this beautiful spot comes to mind. And as you think it over, you go, and you say to yourself, yeah, I think I have just the right spot.

And you go back to the park where the big parent tree is. And with much delight and anticipation, you have this moment where you acknowledge the fruit that fell from this tree not that long ago, that had a seed within it, that you cared for, that you took home, that you planted, that you watered, that you transplanted, that you cared for, is now ready to be out in nature, noticing the cycle of life continuing and the opportunity for this tree to be enjoyed by others. And you let the big parent tree know that you have just a spot in mind.

(32:39 - 35:04)

And although this tree doesn't seem to use words with you, you have this sense of reciprocity from this tree and even a sense of thanks and appreciation from the tree to you for doing such a

good job of caring for its young. And off you go back home, and you prepare your adolescent tree that's already taller than you at this point to be transplanted to its new home. And off you go to that very special place together.

Perhaps you have a cart with you, or something that can help you carry this much larger tree than the little baby one that you first sprouted at home. And you make your way to the location that this tree is going to grow and thrive. And you dig the hole, and you dig it deeper, and you get it to just the right depth for this tree to grow into.

And you have all the soil you need, and you go ahead and you transplant this tree from its pot into the earth. And for the life, it has the pleasure of being planted directly in the earth. And you water it, and you make sure it's doing well.

You add any topsoil that it needs, making sure that it's nice and stable. And you say a little goodbye to this tree that you raised in your home that's now ready for the outside world and to be part of nature. As you walk away, you give a little wave to your tree, heading home, thinking about how happy it's going to be now that it's able to reach out and begin to grow into its full potential in nature.

(35:05 - 36:00)

This tree is big enough and strong enough now that it can make it on its own. It can even find its own water. And the next day, you go back to check on it.

And sure enough, it's doing wonderfully in its new spot. And you go about your day, go to sleep. And the next day, you come back and check again.

And it's doing wonderfully in its new spot. You picked just the right spot for it. You put your hand in the soil and notice that it's still nice and moist, and the tree doesn't need any watering.

It's doing great on its own. And every day for the next few weeks, you come by to check and see how your tree is doing. And it's doing wonderfully.

(36:02 - 36:45)

And before you know it, the seasons are changing. And it's possible that if you have the type of tree that changes with the season, that your tree begins to go through some of these seasonal changes. You may also have the kind of tree that doesn't go through these seasonal changes and stays just the way it is.

And as the weather begins to change to cooler temperatures, your tree does just great. You feel like you don't have to check on it quite as frequently as before. You pop by at least once a week, sometimes more, sometimes less.

(36:46 - 37:54)

And every time you pop by, you notice your tree has gotten bigger and bigger. And as the weeks go by and the months go by, spring returns, and you find that your tree continues to thrive. And as the seasons go by, your tree continues to adapt and grow and thrive and adapt and grow and thrive and adapt and grow and thrive.

And as the months and years go on, you continue to age, noticing the natural transition of your body. And you go and check in on your baby tree that is no longer a baby, and notice that it has matured into a sturdy, beautiful tree. It has so many of the characteristics, colors, shape, and textures of its parent tree in that beautiful park.

(37:56 - 38:23)

And there's a sense of appreciation that you have been part of life perpetuating. You've been an essential ingredient in the success of this life. And as you come back and check on this tree, from time to time, you notice that other people are enjoying it too.

(38:25 - 40:34)

Sometimes children play under this tree. Sometimes teenagers and adults lean against this tree, reading books, listening to music, meditating, or having naps. And as your life goes on and you continue to age, you realize that this tree is still growing.

And it dawns on you one day that this tree is very likely to outlive you. And although your life may come to its natural human end, something really beautiful has been left here. The care, comfort, and support that offer this tree have allowed it to become something really special.

Your continued efforts to help raise this tree and to find a place for it to thrive. All of these efforts, all of this activity, have helped this tree grow from a tiny little sprout into this big, beautiful tree you see before you. So similar in stature and strength and beauty to its parent.

You have been able to enjoy the process of witnessing this life thrive. And you've created, co-created, this opportunity for others to enjoy such a beautiful tree. And maybe in the future, the tree that you planted will finally get to maturity, where it too produces fruit.

(40:36 - 41:21)

And at some point in the future, someone like you may stand there admiring this beautiful tree that you planted and notice that this tree has also borne fruit and left it gently on the ground. And this person too may take this fruit home, discovering its seed, helping this little one churn into a new tree. As the tree you planted continues to grow, a bunch of wonderful creatures have decided to make it a home.

(41:23 - 42:04)

Some parts of the year, birds make their nests in this tree, providing them with a space to raise their young. And deep down in the roots, this tree connects to the mycelial network, touching other roots, sharing resources, connecting to a larger network of nature. One day, someone plants a tree nearby, and deep down in the roots, the tree that you planted and this new tree connect.

(42:06 - 43:27)

Your tree notices that this other tree is young and could use some support and offers it to share its carbon and its water and resources, helping this younger one grow into a big, strong tree as well. And as the years go on, more and more animals make homes in these trees. And more and more people have the opportunity to enjoy spending time under this tree, this tree that you planted so many years ago.

I encourage you to take a few moments to return to your body, return to this room, into the shared space where you are in together, be finding your breath, noticing the floor under your feet. And in your own time, I invite you to gently open your eyes and come back into the shared space.